

The Relation between Faith and Knowledge in its Historical Development

An Introductory Lecture

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The problem of faith and knowledge arises of necessity at a certain stage of cultural development. We encounter it in the Indian, the Greek, and the Muhammadan worlds as soon as intellectual and spiritual development has reached a certain point. Here, however, we shall confine ourselves to tracing the main forms in which it has appeared within the European spiritual development shaped by Christianity.

I.

No instruction on this question can be drawn from the source writings of Christianity. On the standpoint from which they were composed, no knowledge distinct from faith exists. The gaze is fixed on one single object, one single goal, which lays claim to all striving and all spiritual force. The endeavor to know the truth is here immediately one with the urge to win the salvation of the soul, and does not go its own way by its own method. There is no distinction between theory and practice, since theory and theoretical interest simply do not exist. When the Deity itself has revealed itself visibly to all, — when faith makes it possible to attain understanding of the Mystery that contains all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge, — every motive for seeking knowledge by other paths is lacking.

It was natural that faith should from the outset have to be all in all, leaving no room for other spiritual needs. The first generation still stood so close to the mighty spiritual

movement that led to the founding of the Christian community that it lived and breathed entirely in the great memories and visions. Added to this was the fact that this first generation lived in the belief in the imminent return of Christ. Then everything was to be concluded, the last judgment rendered, and all human and earthly arrangements give way to a higher order of things. Who, with such a catastrophe in view, had the time and composure of mind for philosophical thinking or scientific inquiry? Science could no more than any other human endeavor acquire any significance. There was to be no historical development at all; the goal had been reached, and the end stood at the door. One does not understand the New Testament and its relation to cultural endeavor in its various forms unless one holds fast to this. What happened here with scientific striving was the same as with the striving for personal freedom and with the entering into marriage (see 1 Corinthians, ch. 7). How could all such things acquire significance — or even become the object of a drive — when all thoughts and energies had to be strained to be prepared for the great, the absolute decision!

[Sections II–VI: translation forthcoming.]